Allan Gani Panolong

Atty. Allan Gani Panolong is a Filipino lawyer from Lanao del Sur and a proud member of the Meranao people — the indigenous Muslim community of the Lake Lanao basin in Mindanao.

On July 1, 2025, he was sworn in as the **28th National President** of the Integrated Bar of the Philippines (IBP) and Chairperson of its 27th Board of Governors for the term 2025 to 2027, making him the first Muslim and the first Meranao ever to lead the organization in its more than five decades of existence.

That milestone is more than a personal achievement — it represents something the Bangsamoro legal community had long been waiting for: a seat at the very top of the Philippine legal profession for one of their own.

His journey to the IBP's highest post was one he earned step by step: chapter president, regional governor, national executive vice president, and finally, national president — a trajectory that colleagues and observers have called a genuine "rose from the ranks" story.

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Early Life and Family Roots

Panolong comes from the heart of Meranao country in Lanao del Sur, with family roots connecting him to places like Malabang and Butig — communities known for their deep cultural traditions, historical resilience, and the distinct identity of the Meranao people.

Growing up in Lanao del Sur shaped who he is.

The province carries the weight of centuries of Islamic tradition, the enduring values of *maratabat* (roughly understood as personal and family honor), and a community culture that places high regard on education and public service.

Details about his immediate family remain largely private, which is fairly typical of many Mindanao professionals in public life who prefer to keep personal matters separate from their public roles.

What comes through clearly in his public persona, though, is a man firmly grounded in his Meranao identity while navigating and contributing to a national professional arena.

Education

Panolong earned his degree in law from the Mindanao State University (MSU) College of Law, an institution with a well-established reputation for producing lawyers who understand both national jurisprudence and the particular realities of life in Mindanao.

He passed the Philippine Bar Examinations in 2006.

MSU later recognized him with its **Outstanding Rawaten Alumni** distinction, an honor that acknowledges not just academic performance but the kind of practical service and professional leadership that reflects the university's broader mission.

For someone who would go on to lead the national bar, the MSU College of Law was a fitting starting point — an institution that understands what it means to serve a region that has long felt the distance between itself and the corridors of national power.

Career

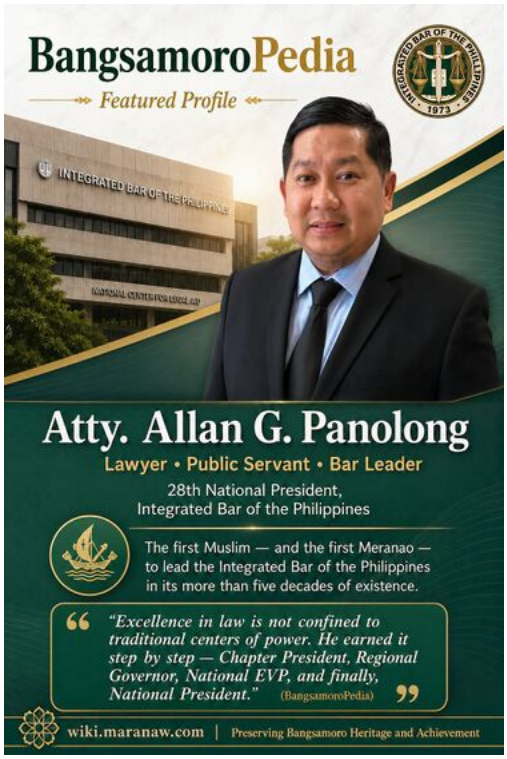
Government Service

Early in his legal career, Panolong served as an **Associate Graft Investigation Officer** at the Office of the Ombudsman, the independent government body tasked with handling complaints of corruption and misconduct by public officials.

The work demanded sharp legal reasoning, strong ethical grounding, and the ability to handle sensitive cases with both rigor and fairness — qualities that would continue to define his professional reputation in the years that followed.

He later crossed into elective public office, serving as a **Provincial Board Member** (Sangguniang Panlalawigan) of Lanao del Sur, where he represented his constituents at the provincial legislative level.

Allan G. Panolong



IBP National President and Chairperson, 27th Board of Governors

Full Name	Allan Gani Panolong
Origin	Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Ethnicity	Meranao (Bangsamoro)
Religion	Islam
Alma Mater	Mindanao State University College of Law
Profession	Lawyer, Public Servant, Bar Leader
Known For	First Muslim and first Meranao IBP National President
Title	28th National President, Integrated Bar of the Philippines
Term	July 1, 2025 – 2027
Preceded By	Atty. Antonio C. Pido (27th National President)

Bar Leadership

Executive Vice President	Atty. Randall C. Tabayoyong

Within the Integrated Bar of the Philippines, Panolong's rise was deliberate and thorough.

He first led the **IBP Lanao del Sur Chapter** as its president, building credibility at the grassroots level of the organization.

From there, he moved up to serve as **Governor for Western Mindanao**, representing the region's lawyers at the IBP's national governing board.

His next step was the **National Executive Vice President** position for the 2023 to 2025 term, a role he served under 27th IBP National President Atty. Antonio C. Pido.

During his tenure as EVP, Panolong also served as a member of the 26th Board of Governors, giving him close exposure to national bar administration and governance before he took the top seat himself.

IBP National Presidency (2025–2027)

Oath-Taking

On July 1, 2025, the Supreme Court of the Philippines held a special session at its Session Hall in Manila for the oath-taking of the 27th Board of Governors of the IBP.

Supreme Court Associate Justice Ramon Paul L. Hernando administered the oath of office to Panolong as the IBP's 28th National President and Chairperson.

Chief Justice Alexander G. Gesmundo and several other associate justices were present at the ceremony.

Joining Panolong in the oath-taking was Executive Vice President Atty. Randall C. Tabayoyong, who also serves as Governor for Bicolandia, along with governors representing all major regions of the country.

Inaugural Address

In his remarks at the ceremony, Panolong underscored the strong partnership between the Supreme Court and the IBP, pointing to their shared commitment to judicial excellence and the rule of law.

He affirmed the IBP's full support for the Supreme Court's Strategic Plan for Judicial Innovations (SPJI) 2022 to 2027, especially in the areas of judicial reform and innovation.

The tone of his address was clear: he intends to lead the bar not as a ceremonial figure but as a working partner with the judiciary in advancing meaningful justice for all Filipinos.

Priorities and Agenda

As National President, Panolong has consistently emphasized that being a lawyer is a privilege that carries serious obligations — not just to clients, but to the broader public.

His administration's agenda centers on several key areas: strengthening the integrity and ethical standards of the legal profession; expanding access to justice, especially in underserved and geographically remote communities; deepening the IBP's pro bono and legal aid programs, including its involvement in the **Unified Legal Aid Service**; supporting anti-political dynasty measures; and reinforcing the IBP's institutional role in upholding constitutional values.

For Panolong, legal professionalism and social responsibility are not separate concerns — they belong together.

Cultural and Symbolic Significance

Panolong's ascent to the IBP's highest post carries meaning that goes well beyond his personal record.

For more than fifty years since the IBP was formally organized, its national leadership was drawn almost entirely from lawyers based in or connected to traditional centers of legal practice in Luzon and the Visayas.

The election and assumption of a Meranao Muslim from Lanao del Sur as the IBP's national president signals a shift in that pattern.

For the Bangsamoro people and Muslim Filipinos more broadly, his leadership represents a form of institutional validation — proof that excellence and credibility in the legal profession are not tied to a particular region, religion, or cultural background.

Colleagues and community members across the Bangsamoro region have described his election as a "proud moment" not only for the Meranao but for the whole of Mindanao.

His story carries a particular resonance for young Muslim Filipinos studying law or entering public service: a Meranao professional who built his career quietly, earned trust at every level of the bar, and eventually led the entire Philippine legal community.

Personal Values and Public Image

From his public statements and conduct in office, Panolong comes across as principled, measured, and deeply committed to institutional integrity.

He speaks with the practicality of someone who has worked at local, regional, and national levels of both government and the bar — someone who understands both the grassroots reality of legal practice in Mindanao and the broader demands of national leadership.

Colleagues describe him as focused on service, respectful of due process, and firm in his belief that the legal profession is — and must be — a force for genuine societal good.

His Meranao identity is not a backdrop to his professional life — it is part of how he understands his responsibilities as a lawyer and as a public servant.

Recognition and Awards

- **Outstanding Rawaten Alumni**, Mindanao State University College of Law
- **First Muslim and First Meranao National President**, Integrated Bar of the Philippines (2025)
- Subject of a formal congratulatory resolution by the **Bangsamoro Parliament** (Resolution No. 347, adopted June 22, 2023), commending his election as IBP National Executive Vice President and his forthcoming

succession to the National Presidency

See Also

- Integrated Bar of the Philippines
- Meranao people
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Mindanao State University
- Lanao del Sur
- Office of the Ombudsman (Philippines)

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External Links

- Official Website of the Integrated Bar of the Philippines (https://www.ibp.ph)
- Official Website of the Supreme Court of the Philippines (https://sc.judiciary.gov.ph)
- Bangsamoro Attorney Generals' Office (https://bago.bangsamoro.gov.ph)

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